Digital Mobilisation vs Youth Apathy: A Documentary Analysis of INEC's Strategic Social Media Engagement Ahead of the 2027 Nigerian Election

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Abstract

Youth participation in Nigerian elections remains a persistent challenge: turnout fell from 69.08% in 2003 to 26.71% in 2023, although citizens aged 18-34 made up about 39.65% of registered voters. This study examined how the Independent National Electoral Commission's (INEC) Department of Voter Education and Publicity (VEP) has used social media to engage youth ahead of 2027. Anchored on Technological Determinism Theory, it used a qualitative documentary design with two data sets: scholarly studies (2014-2026), analysed thematically, and 19 news reports (1 January-10 October 2026), analysed through qualitative content analysis. The scholarly studies show reliance on Facebook and Twitter/X and largely non-interactive content. The news reports show voter education reported mainly as community outreach (9 reports) and training and stakeholder meetings (11); social media featured in 6 reports, and none described interactive or platform-specific content. Reported challenges were misinformation (11 reports), apathy (10) and trust deficits (9); only one acknowledged limited digital access. VEP's reported engagement is audience-targeted but not platform-specific. The study recommends interactivity metrics, platform-specific content, youth-influencer partnerships and attention to access barriers.

Keywords: INEC, 2027 Nigerian elections, Social media, Voter education, Youth apathy, Technological determinism

Introduction

Elections confer legitimacy on leadership and let citizens choose leaders and hold government to account (Diamond, 2002). Since 1999, Nigeria's Independent National Electoral Commission (INEC) has been charged with organising elections and with voter registration, civic education and sustained engagement with the electorate (INEC, 2023). Yet turnout has eroded, particularly among youth: it fell from 69.08 percent in 2003 to 26.71 percent in 2023 (International IDEA, n.d.), even though citizens aged 18-34 formed about 39.65 percent of the 93.4 million registered voters (Okeregbe, 2023). Scholars attribute the 2023 slump to distrust in INEC, fraud, violence and hardship (Akindele et al., 2026), and youth apathy to corruption, marginalisation and broken promises (Mumuni & Abdulyakeen, 2024; Nyitse & Dogo, 2024; Putnam, 2020; Verba et al., 1995).

INEC's Department of Voter Education and Publicity (VEP) sits at the centre of addressing this. It has historically relied on advocacy visits, market outreaches and periodic media campaigns designed for an electorate reached through radio, television and town halls (INEC, 2026c). That sits uneasily against a youth electorate that turns to Instagram, TikTok, WhatsApp, X and LinkedIn for information and community (Nyitse & Dogo, 2024).

Statement of the Problem

Studies of INEC's social media practice point to a gap between presence and engagement. Ibanga et al. (2020) found that only 12 percent of INEC's Facebook and Twitter posts between August 2018 and January 2019 carried direct voter information and 78 percent were non-interactive. Nwoke et al. (2021) found INEC's large

followings under-engaged, and Ayeni and Aweh (2025) reported follower growth between 2018 and 2023 but recommended more interactive, audience-specific content.

Yet apathy appears to respond to deliberate, platform-specific communication. Two quasi-experimental studies in South-East Nigeria found that structured engagement content on Facebook reduced youth apathy more than equivalent content on X (Achebe et al., 2025; Ngwu et al., 2025). They came from the same team, region and journal issue and tested constructed content rather than INEC's own, so they show what platform-specific engagement can achieve, not what VEP does.

Three gaps follow. Studies of INEC's practice end in 2023 and pre-date both the 2027 cycle and the 2026 call for voter education to become "continuous, strategic, targeted, and measurable" (Lashem, 2026). The experimental evidence has not been set against INEC's documented practice. And the INEC-focused work is largely descriptive and, where theory is used, draws on Actor-Network Theory (Ibanga et al., 2020) rather than a communication theory that explains why platform characteristics matter. This study therefore asks whether VEP's social media engagement ahead of 2027, as documented in scholarship and reported in the press, uses the technological characteristics of the platforms in ways that can counter youth apathy.

Research Questions (RQ)

What primary communication channels does VEP use to engage voters, particularly youth?

In what style of communication has VEP packaged its youth-targeted messages?

To what extent has VEP's social media engagement been strategic and platform-specific, as opposed to generic and periodic?

What challenges limit VEP's adoption of sustained, platform-specific social media engagement?

Electioneering, Elections and INEC

Elections are the central mechanism by which democratic societies confer legitimacy on leadership and are expected to be periodic, free, fair and inclusive (Dahl, 1971, as cited in Okafor, 2025). They are an intrinsic aspect of democratic rule (Khan et al., 2021) and are meant to be competitive, open and equal (Blokker, 2021). Electioneering, the campaigning and mobilisation of a nation's population (Adebayo et al., 2024), does not displace the electoral commission's own role (Akubor, 2020). INEC has organised federal elections since 1999 under the 1999 Constitution and the Electoral Act 2022, despite persistent electoral violence, vote buying and declining turnout (INEC, 2023; Okafor, 2025).

Nigeria's election management follows the independent model, with INEC responsible for federal and state elections and State Independent Electoral Commissions for local government elections (Akinduro, 2026; Namo et al., 2024). INEC is entrenched in Section 153 of the 1999 Constitution (INEC, 2026a), and voter and civic education is one of its eight core functions (Channels Television, 2019).

The Roles of INEC's VEP in Audience Participation

VEP is the interface between the Commission and the electorate, charged with informing citizens of their rights and responsibilities to encourage participation and reduce apathy (Ibanga et al., 2020), and it works alongside the media, which, with voters, are indispensable to a credible election (Nigerian Guild of Editors, 2023). Its role covers disseminating accurate information through traditional and digital platforms (INEC, 2026c), countering misinformation, which INEC names as a central challenge ahead of 2027 (Omolaoye, 2026), and building audience participation through interactive content and trained social media staff (Ayeni & Aweh, 2025). VEP's role therefore extends from publicity, the broadcasting of messages, to engagement, interaction that invites the audience to respond.

Youth Apathy and Social Media

Political apathy denotes disengagement from civic processes, often rooted in powerlessness (Achebe et al., 2025; Ekwenchi & Udenze, 2014), and in Nigeria it stems from disillusionment, corruption, violence and marginalisation (Nyitse & Dogo, 2024). Other causes cited include bad governance, unfulfilled campaign promises, rigging, thuggery and poverty, and in Ebonyi State the Resident Electoral Commissioner reported that only about 30 percent of eligible voters took part in the 2015 general elections (Ngene et al., 2024).

Social media are Web 2.0 applications that enable user-generated content and two-way interaction, unlike the one-way model of traditional mass media (Kaplan & Haenlein, 2010, as cited in Ibanga et al., 2020), and in Nigeria platforms such as Facebook, X, Instagram, WhatsApp and TikTok are primary sources of political news among youth (Nyitse & Dogo, 2024).

Youth themselves rate these platforms highly: in a survey of 200 youths aged 18-35 in Kwara State, over 70 percent named social media networks as the tools with the greatest potential to mobilise young people, yet much of this activity stayed online and did not become offline participation, a pattern the study calls slacktivism (Maxwell, 2025).

Audience engagement refers to the depth and quality of interaction rather than mere exposure, a distinction between presence and engagement that anchors this study. Access conditions shape it: high data costs, poor connectivity, network fluctuations, inadequate electricity and the 2021 Twitter/X suspension limited online participation (Bassey et al., 2026; Maduagugbuo, 2026).

Theoretical Framework

This study is anchored on Technological Determinism Theory, which holds that communication technologies are a primary force shaping how societies organise, perceive and act (McLuhan, 1964). It draws on Innis's (1951) idea that media carry biases and McLuhan's (1964) proposition that the medium, more than its content, shapes the scale and form of human interaction.

Applied to political communication, it directs attention to what a platform makes possible: its reach, speed, interactivity and format. Three ideas guide the study. First, the characteristics of a medium shape the form of the message, so the styles of communication VEP uses (RQ2) are partly a function of its channels (RQ1). Second, the benefits of a technology depend on whether its distinctive characteristics are used: a platform built for two-way interaction but used for one-way announcements delivers reach without engagement (Ibanga et al., 2020), the concern of RQ3.

Third, conditions such as connectivity, data costs, electricity and platform availability enable or constrain participation, which makes them central to RQ4 (Bassey et al., 2026; Maduagugbuo, 2026). A strong form of determinism understates human agency, so the study adopts a soft form, in which technology shapes what is possible but institutional choices determine how far possibilities are used. Trust, capacity and political context are treated as conditions that interact with technology.

Methodology

The study used a qualitative documentary research design, in which existing documents are located, selected and interpreted to answer research questions (Bowen, 2009). Evidence came from three sources handled as two separate data sets: scholarly studies on INEC's social media practice, youth political apathy and platform-specific engagement, published between 2014 and 2026, and news reports on INEC's voter education and publicity activities, published between 1 January and 10 October 2026, the date of data collection.

INEC's own documents, such as its National Voter Education Manual and voter education guidelines,

established the Commission's stated policy and were not coded (INEC, 2026b, 2026c). Scholarly studies were analysed thematically with Braun and Clarke's (2006) six-phase framework, and news reports through qualitative content analysis, a systematic method for describing the manifest and latent meaning of texts and drawing replicable inferences from them (Krippendorff, 2018).

The findings are reported separately and compared only in the discussion, so that news reports are not treated as research evidence.

Scholarly studies were purposively selected if they were journal articles, theses or academic manuscripts directly addressing voter education, youth political apathy or social media engagement in Nigeria; opinion pieces, blogs, irrelevant non-Nigerian studies and sources without clear authorship were excluded.

News reports were purposively selected through web searches combining "INEC", "voter education", "social media", "youth", "apathy", "misinformation", "manual", "radio" and "2027". A report was retained if it was published within the study period, reported an INEC official's statement or activity on voter education or publicity, and was a straight news report or interview. Editorials, opinion columns, non-news event write-ups and paid advertorials were excluded, and where several outlets covered the same event only the fullest account was kept. Of 30 reports screened, 19 were included.

The individual report was the unit of analysis, and the manifest statement referring to a channel, communication style, strategy or challenge was the coding unit, coded against a scheme derived deductively from the research questions and theoretical framework (Table 1). Coded statements were counted and grouped by research question. Statements were coded as stated, and no claim was treated as evidence of practice unless the report described an action rather than an intention.

Table 1

Coding Scheme for the Content Analysis of News Reports

Research question (RQ)

Coding category (what is recorded)

Technological Determinism concept

RQ1: Channels

Platform or channel named (Facebook, X, Instagram, YouTube, WhatsApp, TikTok, radio, television, print, in-person)

Medium as the carrier that shapes reach

RQ2: Style of Communication

Type of message (explainer video, short video, poll, live Q&A, activity report, announcement, manual, skit or meme)

Medium characteristics shape message form

RQ3: Strategy

Interactivity (one-way or two-way); platform-specific or generic; continuous or election-season only; evidence of measurement

Whether affordances are exploited

RQ4: Challenges

Barrier named (trust, connectivity, data cost, electricity, capacity, political or platform restriction, misinformation)

Technological conditions that enable or constrain

To strengthen reliability, the 19 reports were coded with AI assistance (Anthropic Claude, Version 1.260914.19) applying the codebook in Table 1, and the lead author (Suleiman) reviewed the coding decisions against the source reports. A second coder, the research assistant (Eletu), blind to the first coder's decisions, independently coded four reports (N01 to N04, about 21% of the sample), scoring each category as present (1) or absent (0). Agreement was complete across all 116 coding decisions (percent agreement = 100%; Cohen's = 1.00), though the small subsample and manifest codebook mean this shows consistent application of the rules and not a full reliability test.

Triangulating scholarly studies, news reports and INEC's documents strengthened validity. The study used only public documents and no human participants, so informed consent and ethical approval were not required. Limitations include the absence of INEC's internal documents and real-time social media data, a thin empirical base on INEC's practice, and reliance on researcher judgement in source selection, constrained by explicit criteria.

Presentation of Results According to Research Questions

This section reports results for each research question: first what the scholarly studies show (Table 2), then what the 19 news reports show, coded against Table 1. In the news-report tables, n is the number of reports in which a category appeared. The two sets are compared in Section 5. Appendix A lists the sample.

Table 2

Summary of Scholarly Evidence on INEC's Voter Education by Research Question

Study and method

RQ

Finding

Ibanga et al. (2020); content analysis of INEC's Facebook and Twitter, 2018-2019

1-3

Facebook and Twitter were the two active channels. Posts: voter information 12%, electoral system education 24%, offline voter education reports 38%, other matters 26%. 78% non-interactive, 22% reactive, none conversational.

Nwoke et al. (2021); cyber-ethnography, 2019 cycle

1-4

Facebook (about 400,000 followers) and Twitter (1.8 million) were primary; YouTube was largely dormant. Explainer videos were used; citizen hashtags and skits (#GetYourPVC, #PVCisagoal) amplified INEC's message. Content was under-engaged. Barriers: distrust, indifference to non-sensational content, poor rural connectivity, propaganda framing.

Ayeni & Aweh (2025); audit, 2018-2023

1-4

Facebook, X, Instagram and YouTube tracked; INEC had the largest follower count among the election bodies

of Nigeria, South Africa, Kenya and Ghana. Posts mostly static; Facebook followers grew 205%; interactive posts earned about twice the engagement. Gaps: no regular handler training, no audience-specific strategy, limited paid promotion.

Maduagugbuo (2026); youth survey

3-4

Two-way communication scored lowest (M = 2.38). Data costs, poor connectivity, the 2021 Twitter/X suspension (63.5%), hate speech and peer indifference limited participation.

Bassey et al. (2026); Akwa Ibom survey

1, 4

WhatsApp (25.0%) and Facebook (22.4%) were most used for electoral education content; network fluctuations (35.5%) and inadequate electricity (32.0%) were leading constraints. Not specific to INEC.

Achebe et al. (2025); Ngwu et al. (2025); quasi-experiments

3

Sustained, platform-specific, interactive content, especially on Facebook, significantly reduced apathy; a benchmark, not evidence of VEP practice.

Ekwenchi & Udenze (2014); NOA e-polling survey

4

66% were unaware of the platform; 53% of those aware saw it as propaganda.

Okafor (2025); documentary analysis

4

Apathy is one of several interlocking capacity challenges (with funding, staffing and security) needing sustained civic-education investment.

Note. Findings are as reported in the cited studies.

Research Question One: What Primary Communication Channels Does VEP Use to Engage Voters, Particularly Youth?

Between 2018 and 2023, Facebook and Twitter/X were INEC's main channels, with Instagram and YouTube secondary and YouTube largely dormant (Ayeni & Aweh, 2025; Ibanga et al., 2020; Nwoke et al., 2021). The one electorate survey found WhatsApp and Facebook most used for electoral education content (Bassey et al., 2026), suggesting a gap between where INEC posted and where audiences received content, although that sample was local and not specific to INEC.

Table 3

Channels Reported in News Reports on INEC's Voter Education, 1 January-10 October 2026

Category

n (%)

Reports

Community and in-person outreach (markets, motor parks, campuses, religious and traditional institutions, town halls, town criers)

9 (47.4%)

N03, N05, N08, N09, N13, N14, N15, N17, N19

Social media and digital platforms

6 (31.6%)

N04, N10, N13, N14, N16, N17

Mass media (radio, television, print, media partnerships)

6 (31.6%)

N01, N02, N07, N14, N15, N18

Partner agencies and influencers

6 (31.6%)

N03, N06, N09, N16, N18, N19

No public-facing channel described

2 (10.5%)

N11, N12

Note. n = 19 reports. A report can appear in more than one category, so percentages do not sum to 100. Report IDs are listed in Appendix A.

Community and in-person outreach was the most frequently reported channel (9 of 19 reports, 47.4%), for example directing Osun officers to markets, motor parks and religious centres (N08) and urging Sokoto officers to use town criers (N17). Social media, mass media, and partner agencies and influencers each appeared in 6 reports (31.6%). Only one platform, X, was named, in one report (Akhimien, 2026); Facebook, Instagram, YouTube, TikTok and WhatsApp were named in none. Two reports (Ogunseyin, 2026; Omolaoye, 2026) described internal meetings and named no public-facing channel.

Research Question Two: In What Style of Communication Has VEP Packaged Its Youth-Targeted Messages?

INEC's output leaned towards institutional activity reports rather than direct voter instruction, with offline voter education reports the largest category (38%) (Ibanga et al., 2020). Where instruction appeared, it took the form of explainer videos, and the content that amplified INEC's message most effectively was citizen-generated skits, memes and hashtags (Nwoke et al., 2021). Posts were largely static, and interactive posts earned about twice the engagement (Ayeni & Aweh, 2025).

Table 4

Styles of Communication Reported in News Reports on INEC's Voter Education, 1 January-10 October 2026

Category

n (%)

Reports

Training workshops and stakeholder meetings

11 (57.9%)

N01, N02, N07, N08, N09, N11, N12, N13, N14, N17, N19

Community sessions, public events and sensitisation campaigns

7 (36.8%)

N03, N04, N05, N08, N14, N15, N16

Radio or television programme

2 (10.5%)

N15, N18

No message style described

2 (10.5%)

N06, N10

Print manuals

1 (5.3%)

N04

Social media post or announcement

1 (5.3%)

N04

Interactive digital content (explainer or short videos, polls, live Q&A, memes)

0 (0.0%)

None

Note. n = 19 reports. A report can appear in more than one category, so percentages do not sum to 100. Report IDs are listed in Appendix A.

The reported styles were overwhelmingly institutional events: training workshops and stakeholder meetings (11 reports) and community sessions, public events and sensitisation campaigns (7). Only 3 reports described a message produced for a particular medium: a statement on X (Akhimien, 2026) and radio programmes (Leonard, 2026; Idakwo, 2026a). No report described explainer or short videos, polls, live question-and-answer sessions or memes. This is a limit of the data as well as a finding, because a news report is more likely to be written about a workshop than about a post.

Research Question Three: To What Extent Has VEP's Social Media Engagement Been Strategic and Platform-Specific, as Opposed to Generic and Periodic?

Between 2018 and 2023, VEP's presence expanded in reach but stayed largely non-interactive: Ibanga et al. (2020) found no conversational posts, Nwoke et al. (2021) concluded that online activity was a poor predictor of election outcomes, Ayeni and Aweh (2025) reported follower growth alongside calls for interactive, targeted content, and youth ranked two-way communication lowest (Maduagugbuo, 2026). The quasi-experimental

studies (Achebe et al., 2025; Ngwu et al., 2025) offer a benchmark that none of the studies of INEC's own practice showed it meeting, but, as noted in Section 1.1, it is a benchmark and not evidence of what VEP achieved.

Table 5

Strategy Features Reported in News Reports on INEC's Voter Education, 1 January-10 October 2026

Category

n (%)

Reports

Partnerships with agencies, media, civil society or community leaders

14 (73.7%)

N01, N02, N03, N04, N06, N07, N08, N09, N14, N15, N16, N17, N18, N19

Audience targeting (youth, women, persons with disabilities, rural communities)

13 (68.4%)

N03, N04, N06, N07, N08, N10, N11, N13, N14, N15, N16, N17, N19

Counter-misinformation as an aim

10 (52.6%)

N07, N08, N09, N11, N12, N14, N15, N16, N17, N19

Digital engagement intention or instruction stated

5 (26.3%)

N04, N10, N13, N16, N17

Continuous education stated

3 (15.8%)

N03, N09, N17

Dialogic or two-way engagement

2 (10.5%)

N03, N14

Evaluation or measurement

2 (10.5%)

N11, N17

Platform-specific content

0 (0.0%)

None

Note. n = 19 reports. A report can appear in more than one category, so percentages do not sum to 100. Report IDs are listed in Appendix A.

Partnerships (14 of 19 reports, 73.7%) and audience targeting (13, 68.4%) were the most frequently reported features, followed by counter-misinformation as an aim (10). A stated intention or instruction to engage digitally appeared in 5 reports, continuous education in 3, dialogic engagement in 2 and evaluation in 2. No report described platform-specific content. These are statements of intention reported by journalists from INEC officials, and none gave results, budgets or measures of reach, so none allows the claimed strategy to be verified.

Research Question Four: What Challenges Limit VEP's Adoption of Sustained, Platform-Specific Social Media Engagement?

The studies identify four kinds of constraint. At the trust level, youth often distrust official platforms and dismiss them as propaganda (Ekwenchi & Udenze, 2014; Nwoke et al., 2021). At the infrastructure level, poor connectivity, high data costs and unreliable electricity limit access, particularly for rural and low-income groups (Bassey et al., 2026; Maduagugbuo, 2026). At the capacity level, there is a lack of training, tailored content and paid promotion (Ayeni & Aweh, 2025; Okafor, 2025). At the political-environment level, the 2021 suspension of Twitter/X discouraged youth participation (Maduagugbuo, 2026).

Table 6

Challenges Reported in News Reports on INEC's Voter Education, 1 January-10 October 2026

Category

n (%)

Reports

Misinformation and disinformation

11 (57.9%)

N07, N08, N09, N11, N12, N13, N14, N15, N16, N17, N19

Voter apathy or low turnout

10 (52.6%)

N03, N04, N07, N08, N09, N10, N11, N12, N13, N14

Trust deficit or credibility doubts

9 (47.4%)

N03, N07, N08, N09, N11, N12, N13, N15, N19

Low civic knowledge

4 (21.1%)

N03, N04, N08, N09

Reach and logistics

4 (21.1%)

N11, N12, N14, N17

Vote buying, violence or misuse of youth

3 (15.8%)

N14, N15, N16

Limited access to digital sources (including connectivity, data costs, electricity)

1 (5.3%)

N17

Platform or political restrictions on social media

0 (0.0%)

None

No challenge stated

5 (26.3%)

N01, N02, N05, N06, N18

Note. n = 19 reports. A report can appear in more than one category, so percentages do not sum to 100. Report IDs are listed in Appendix A.

INEC's reported challenges were mainly attitudinal and informational: misinformation or disinformation (11 reports, 57.9%), voter apathy or low turnout (10, 52.6%) and a trust deficit (9, 47.4%). Low civic knowledge and reach and logistics each appeared in 4 reports, and vote buying, violence or misuse of youth in 3. One report (Lashem, 2026) acknowledged citizens with limited access to digital sources of electoral information, but no report named connectivity, data costs or electricity, and none mentioned platform restrictions. Five reports named no challenge.

Discussion of Findings

The finding that INEC works through a mix of channels agrees with the scholarly record and adds to it. Earlier studies show a large but largely one-directional social media presence (Ayeni & Aweh, 2025; Ibanga et al., 2020; Nwoke et al., 2021), while the 2026 reports show social media as one channel among several, with the weight on community contact and partner networks. Community channels reach people who are offline but cannot supply the speed, scale or traceable two-way interaction of social media. That only 6 of 19 reports mention social media, and only one names a platform, suggests that platforms are discussed as places to be present rather than as technologies with particular capabilities, the presence without engagement identified by Ibanga et al. (2020). This fits the soft form of the theory adopted here: technology offers possibilities, but institutional choices decide how far they are used.

The reported styles of communication follow the same pattern. Offline activity reports were the largest category of INEC's posts in 2018-2019 (Ibanga et al., 2020), and the 2026 reports are themselves mostly accounts of workshops, meetings and events. No report described explainer videos, short videos, polls, live question-and-answer sessions or memes, the styles Ayeni and Aweh (2025) recommend and that Nwoke et al. (2021) found citizens using to amplify INEC's message. News reports are written about events, so their silence does not prove that VEP does not use such styles. What they show is that, in the public record of 2026, voter education is presented as institutional activity rather than content designed for a platform, whereas under Technological Determinism a platform that rewards short, visual and interactive content calls for content of that kind.

On strategy, INEC's reported approach is relational and targeted. Partnership appeared in 14 reports and audience targeting in 13, and the youth ambassador scheme (Adesina, 2026) is the clearest move towards the influencer-based communication that Nwoke et al. (2021) found effective when it came from citizens. The features that Achebe et al. (2025) and Ngwu et al. (2025) associate with reduced apathy (sustained, platform-specific, interactive content) were reported rarely or not at all: continuous education in 3 reports, evaluation in 2 and platform-specific content in none. The report that came closest set such aims as an expectation placed on officers (Lashem, 2026) and reported no results. By that benchmark the reported strategy is incomplete, and digital engagement appears only as an intention (5 reports), so presence can still be mistaken for engagement, as Ibanga et al. (2020) cautioned.

Trust is common ground between INEC and the scholars: 9 reports name a trust deficit or doubts about credibility, and Ekwenchi and Udenze (2014) and Nwoke et al. (2021) found the same barrier among youth. The difference lies in what is missing. Bassey et al. (2026) and Maduagugbuo (2026) found that network fluctuations, electricity, data costs and the 2021 Twitter/X suspension limited online participation, yet no report names any of these; the nearest is a Sokoto briefing urging officers to reach citizens with limited digital access (Lashem, 2026). INEC's account is attitudinal and informational, whereas the scholarly account adds technological and structural conditions. For Technological Determinism these are central, because a platform can shape participation only for those who can reach it.

Three limits qualify these points. The news reports are indirect evidence of what officials said and journalists chose to report. The sample was drawn by purposive web search and is not an exhaustive archive of 2026 coverage. And the scholarly studies cover 2018 to 2023 while the news reports cover 2026, so differences may reflect change over time as well as method. The comparison is between two records of INEC's practice, not two measurements of the same thing.

Implications of the Study

Theoretically, the study applies Technological Determinism in its soft form to an institution's communication practice, showing the difference between a platform's presence and the use of its characteristics, and shows the theory's limit here, since the barriers that matter most (trust, capacity and access) are institutional and social. For policy, VEP should measure engagement beyond follower counts, publish platform-specific plans and results, and extend its existing staff training (John, 2026; Lashem, 2026; Osoteku, 2026) to interactive content design. For scholarship, the study adds a systematic content analysis of 2026 news reports tied to a communication theory; future work should analyse INEC's actual 2026-2027 posts and test whether the South-East experimental findings hold for INEC's own content and other regions.

Conclusion

This study asked whether INEC's Department of Voter Education and Publicity has adapted its social media engagement to counter youth apathy ahead of 2027. The scholarly studies show a large but largely one-directional presence between 2018 and 2023. The 19 news reports from 2026 show an approach that relies on community outreach, training and partnerships, with social media mentioned in a minority of reports, no interactive styles of communication or platform-specific content described, and one passing acknowledgement of limited digital access. On the available evidence, the reported strategy is targeted but not platform-specific, though because the evidence is indirect this applies to what VEP has made public.

Recommendations

The study makes six recommendations:

Adopt interactivity metrics, judging social media work by response rates, comment activity and completion of

interactive content rather than follower counts, and publish the results (Ibanga et al., 2020; Nwoke et al., 2021).

Shift content towards direct voter information and interactive content such as short videos, live question-and-answer sessions and polls (Achebe et al., 2025; Ayeni & Aweh, 2025; Ngwu et al., 2025).

Formalise youth-influencer partnerships and evaluate the youth ambassador scheme (Adesina, 2026), building on citizen-led campaigns such as #GetYourPVC and #PVCisagoal (Nwoke et al., 2021).

Choose platforms by where young voters are. Facebook outperformed X in the South-East experiments (Achebe et al., 2025; Ngwu et al., 2025) and WhatsApp was among the most used in Akwa Ibom (Bassey et al., 2026), yet no 2026 report names WhatsApp, so VEP should pilot content on both.

Keep a hybrid outreach model and plan for access barriers, pairing digital work with radio, community and in-person channels (Lashem, 2026; Leonard, 2026; Osoteku, 2026) so that rural and low-income youth are not excluded (Bassey et al., 2026; Maduagugbuo, 2026).

Extend staff training to interactive content design and platform-specific strategy for those who handle social media (Ayeni & Aweh, 2025; John, 2026; Lashem, 2026; Osoteku, 2026).

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56. Appendix A

57. Sample of News Reports on INEC's Voter Education (N = 19), 1 January-10 October 2026

58. ID

59. In-text citation

60. Outlet

61. Date

62. Headline
63. N01
64. (Agboluaje, 2026)
65. The Guardian Nigeria
66. 15 Jan 2026
67. INEC, NUJ forge alliance to deepen voter education in Oyo
68. N02
69. (Akinwale, 2026)
70. ThisDay
71. 3 Feb 2026
72. INEC urges media to intensify voter education ahead of FCT Area Council elections
73. N03
74. (Ogundare, 2026)
75. ThisDay
76. 13 Mar 2026
77. INEC calls for grassroots mobilisation to boost voter participation in Lagos
78. N04
79. (Akhimien, 2026)
80. Channels Television
81. 26 Mar 2026
82. 2027: INEC launches new voter education manuals to combat apathy
83. N05
84. (Peoples Gazette, 2026a)
85. Peoples Gazette
86. 1 Apr 2026
87. INEC launches voter enlightenment drive in Kano
88. N06
89. (Peoples Gazette, 2026b)
90. Peoples Gazette
91. 16 Apr 2026
92. INEC reaffirms commitment to youth inclusion
93. N07
94. (Sodeinde, 2026)
95. ThisDay
96. 28 May 2026
97. Ekiti: INEC enlists media against fake news, says poll critical to 2027 credibility
98. N08
99. (Adewole, 2026)
100. The Guardian Nigeria
101. 1 Jun 2026
102. Osun 2026: INEC charges electoral officers on grassroot voter education

103. N09
104. (Nze, 2026)
105. Blueprint
106. 2 Jul 2026
107. 2027 elections: INEC, NOA move to rebuild public trust, boost voter education
108. N10
109. (Idakwo, 2026b)
110. Leadership
111. 25 Jul 2026
112. 2027: Youths dominate new voter registration, account for 67.4 percent
113. N11
114. (Ogunseyin, 2026)
115. The Guardian Nigeria
116. 18 Aug 2026
117. 2027 election: No eligible Nigerian must be left behind, says INEC
118. N12
119. (Omolaoye, 2026)
120. The Guardian Nigeria
121. 7 Sep 2026
122. 2027: INEC identifies voter apathy, disinformation as threats
123. N13
124. (John, 2026)
125. News Agency of Nigeria
126. 14 Sep 2026
127. INEC trains personnel to boost voter confidence ahead of 2027 elections
128. N14
129. (Osoteku, 2026)
130. Voice of Nigeria
131. 15 Sep 2026
132. 2027 election: INEC intensifies grassroots voter education
133. N15
134. (Leonard, 2026)
135. The Legal Observer
136. 17 Sep 2026
137. Ogun: INEC records 15,777 voter transfers, 6,063 PVC collections
138. N16
139. (Adesina, 2026)
140. P.M. News
141. 2 Oct 2026
142. 2027: 9.3m young Nigerians join voter roll - INEC
143. N17

144. (Lashem, 2026)
145. NewsDiaryOnline
146. 14 Sep 2026
147. 2027: INEC tasks officers on continuous, strategic voter education
148. N18
149. (Idakwo, 2026a)
150. Leadership
151. 20 Feb 2026
152. INEC, NOA step up radio sensitisation for FCT polls
153. N19
154. (Onuado, 2026)
155. Leadership
156. 25 Jun 2026
157. INEC warns against misinformation, seeks stronger voter education
158. Note. N01 to N16 are in date order. N17 to N19 were added later and followed in the order they were screened.